demonetization exercise. On 4 September 2016, Urjit Patel took over as the twenty-fourth Governor of the RBI.

Was Raghuram G. Rajan aware of the demonetization? Did he oppose it? Could this have been the reason for the orchestrated campaign to remove him from the position?

When requested for information in early 2017, Rajan's response was courteous but circumspect: 'Sorry, not speaking on India till September 2017, and really cannot speak on discussions with the Govt. Many of your questions can be asked to RBI management. They can decide what they can answer.'

On its part, the RBI declined to share any information. In response to numerous RTI requests by concerned citizens, it declined to furnish information citing section 8(1)(g) of the RTI Act. Shailesh Gandhi, the former Central Information Commissioner, whose previous rulings that the RBI must disclose information were upheld by the Supreme Court, said, 'The RBI is treating the orders of the Commission, the Supreme Court, and the RTI Act made by Parliament, in complete contempt.'[20]

Then in September 2017, Rajan broke his silence. Speaking at the launch of his book *I Do What I Do*, he disclosed that he had opposed demonetization as he felt the short-term economic costs associated with such a disruptive decision would outweigh any longer-term benefits from it.

'I made these views known in no uncertain terms… *At no point during my term was the RBI asked to make a decision on demonetization*… I was asked by the government in February 2016 for my view on demonetization, which I gave orally.'[21]

Despite his reservations, the RBI was asked to prepare a note for submission to the government. Rajan said, 'The RBI note outlined potential costs and benefits of demonetization, as well as alternatives that could achieve similar aims. If the government, on weighing the pros and cons, still decided to go ahead with demonetization, the *note outlined the preparation that would be needed, and the time that*